

CHOOSING LIFE

A Self-Harm Recovery Workbook for Teens & Young Adults

By Daniel Tesfamariam

You matter. Your pain is real.
And you deserve to find another way.

Copyright - Daniel Tesfamariam

All rights reserved.

CRISIS RESOURCES:

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: Call or text 988

Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741

This workbook is not a substitute for professional help.

UNDERSTANDING SELF-HARM

Self-harm is NOT:

- Attention-seeking
- A failed suicide attempt (though risk increases)
- Something to be ashamed of

Self-harm IS:

- A coping mechanism for overwhelming emotions
- A way to feel something when feeling numb
- A signal that you need and deserve support

Common reasons people self-harm:

- To manage intense emotions
- To feel in control
- To express pain they can't put into words
- To punish themselves
- To feel something when numb

Recovery IS possible. Many people find healthier ways to cope.

MY TRIGGERS

Triggers are situations, feelings, or thoughts that make you want to self-harm.
Identifying them is the first step to managing them.

EMOTIONAL TRIGGERS (feelings that come before the urge):

SITUATIONAL TRIGGERS (events, places, people):

THOUGHT TRIGGERS (what I tell myself before an urge):

BODY SIGNALS (physical signs an urge is building):

URGE SURFING TECHNIQUE

Urges are like waves - they rise, peak, and pass.

The average urge lasts 15-30 minutes if you don't act on it.

STEPS TO SURF AN URGE:

1. NOTICE: 'I'm having an urge right now.' Name it without judgment.
2. BREATHE: Take 5 slow breaths. In for 4, hold for 4, out for 6.
3. OBSERVE: Where do you feel the urge in your body? Rate it 1-10.
4. DESCRIBE: What triggered this? What emotion is underneath?
5. RIDE: The urge WILL pass. Set a timer for 15 minutes.
6. DISTRACT: Use a coping skill (next page) until the wave passes.
7. CELEBRATE: You surfed the urge! Record your success.

My urge rating right now (1-10): _____

Timer set for: _____ minutes

What I notice about the urge after waiting:

ALTERNATIVE COPING STRATEGIES

Instead of harming, try these alternatives that address the SAME need:

FOR INTENSE EMOTIONS (need to feel something physical):

- Hold ice cubes tightly
- Snap a rubber band on wrist
- Take a very cold shower
- Bite into a lemon or hot pepper
- Squeeze a stress ball as hard as possible

FOR ANGER/FRUSTRATION:

- Rip up paper or an old phone book
- Scream into a pillow
- Punch a punching bag or pillow
- Run or do intense exercise
- Write angry words and burn the paper safely

FOR SADNESS/NUMBNESS (need to feel):

- Draw on skin with RED marker where you would harm
- Hold ice on your skin
- Take a cold shower
- Eat something with intense flavor
- Listen to loud emotional music

FOR SELF-PUNISHMENT:

- Write a letter of self-compassion
- Do something kind for someone else
- Challenge the thought: 'What would I say to a friend?'
- List 3 things you did well today

MY TOP 3 GO-TO ALTERNATIVES:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

DISTRESS TOLERANCE SKILLS

The TIPP Skills (change your body chemistry fast):

- T - Temperature:** Dunk face in cold water or hold ice to face for 30 sec
- I - Intense Exercise:** Sprint, jump, do burpees for 5-10 minutes
- P - Paced Breathing:** Breathe out longer than in (4 in, 7 out)
- P - Paired Muscle Relaxation:** Tense each muscle group, then release

The ACCEPTS Skills (distraction when emotions are HIGH):

- A - Activities:** Do something that requires focus
- C - Contributing:** Help someone else, volunteer, do a kind act
- C - Comparisons:** Compare to a time you coped well
- E - Emotions:** Watch a funny video, listen to upbeat music
- P - Pushing Away:** Mentally put the problem on a shelf for now
- T - Thoughts:** Count backwards from 100 by 7s
- S - Sensations:** Hold ice, smell strong scent, taste something sour

Which TIPP skill works best for me? _____

Which ACCEPTS skill works best for me? _____

EMOTION REGULATION BASICS

Self-harm often happens when emotions feel unmanageable.

These skills help you manage emotions BEFORE they reach crisis level.

THE EMOTION WAVE:

Trigger -> Thought -> Emotion -> Urge -> Action

You can interrupt at ANY point in this chain!

NAME IT TO TAME IT:

Right now I feel: _____

On a scale of 1-10, the intensity is: _____

This emotion is telling me: _____

OPPOSITE ACTION:

When the emotion is NOT justified or when acting on it would be harmful:

Sadness urge: withdraw

Opposite: reach out to someone, get active

Anger urge: attack

Opposite: gently avoid, do something kind

Fear urge: avoid

Opposite: approach what you fear (safely)

Shame urge: hide

Opposite: tell someone, show yourself

My emotion that most often leads to self-harm: _____

My opposite action plan: _____

MY SAFETY PLAN

Step 1: Warning signs that a crisis may be building:

Step 2: Internal coping strategies (things I can do alone):

Step 3: People who can distract me:

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Step 4: People I can ask for help:

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Step 5: Professionals/agencies I can contact:

Therapist: _____ Phone: _____

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (call or text 988)

Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741

Emergency: 911

Step 6: Making my environment safe (removing means):

My one reason to stay safe today:

WOUND CARE INFORMATION

If you have harmed, caring for wounds is an act of self-compassion.

BASIC FIRST AID:

1. Wash hands before touching any wound
2. Clean the wound gently with cool running water
3. Apply gentle pressure with clean cloth if bleeding
4. Apply antibiotic ointment if available
5. Cover with a clean bandage
6. Change bandage daily and watch for infection

SEEK MEDICAL HELP IF:

- Bleeding won't stop after 10 minutes of pressure
- Wound is deep, wide, or won't close
- Signs of infection (redness spreading, warmth, pus, fever)
- You feel dizzy or faint
- You are in severe pain

Remember: Getting medical help is NOT shameful.

You deserve care and healing.

MY TRUSTED ADULTS

Having at least ONE adult who knows what you're going through is critical.

A trusted adult is someone who:

- Listens without judgment
- Keeps appropriate confidences
- Doesn't minimize your pain
- Helps you get professional support
- Checks in on you without being controlling

MY TRUSTED PEOPLE:

Person 1: _____ Relationship: _____

Phone/Contact: _____

What I want them to know:

Person 2: _____ Relationship: _____

Phone/Contact: _____

What I want them to know:

Person 3: _____ Relationship: _____

Phone/Contact: _____

What I want them to know:

Person 4: _____ Relationship: _____

Phone/Contact: _____

What I want them to know:

WEEKLY URGE TRACKER - WEEK 1

Monday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Tuesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Wednesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Thursday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Friday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Saturday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Sunday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____

Highest urge this week: ____ Lowest: ____ Average: ____

Harm-free days this week: ____/7

What helped most this week:

What I'm proud of:

Goal for next week:

WEEKLY URGE TRACKER - WEEK 2

Monday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Tuesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Wednesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Thursday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Friday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Saturday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Sunday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____

Highest urge this week: ____ Lowest: ____ Average: ____

Harm-free days this week: ____/7

What helped most this week:

What I'm proud of:

Goal for next week:

WEEKLY URGE TRACKER - WEEK 3

Monday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Tuesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Wednesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Thursday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Friday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Saturday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Sunday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____

Highest urge this week: ____ Lowest: ____ Average: ____

Harm-free days this week: ____/7

What helped most this week:

What I'm proud of:

Goal for next week:

WEEKLY URGE TRACKER - WEEK 4

Monday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?: Y/N	Skill used: _____
Tuesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?: Y/N	Skill used: _____
Wednesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?: Y/N	Skill used: _____
Thursday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?: Y/N	Skill used: _____
Friday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?: Y/N	Skill used: _____
Saturday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?: Y/N	Skill used: _____
Sunday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?: Y/N	Skill used: _____

Highest urge this week: ____ Lowest: ____ Average: ____

Harm-free days this week: ____/7

What helped most this week:

What I'm proud of:

Goal for next week:

WEEKLY URGE TRACKER - WEEK 5

Monday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Tuesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Wednesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Thursday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Friday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Saturday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Sunday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____

Highest urge this week: ____ Lowest: ____ Average: ____

Harm-free days this week: ____/7

What helped most this week:

What I'm proud of:

Goal for next week:

WEEKLY URGE TRACKER - WEEK 6

Monday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Tuesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Wednesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Thursday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Friday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Saturday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Sunday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____

Highest urge this week: ____ Lowest: ____ Average: ____

Harm-free days this week: ____/7

What helped most this week:

What I'm proud of:

Goal for next week:

WEEKLY URGE TRACKER - WEEK 7

Monday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Tuesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Wednesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Thursday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Friday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Saturday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Sunday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____

Highest urge this week: ____ Lowest: ____ Average: ____

Harm-free days this week: ____/7

What helped most this week:

What I'm proud of:

Goal for next week:

WEEKLY URGE TRACKER - WEEK 8

Monday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Tuesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Wednesday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Thursday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Friday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Saturday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____
Sunday	Urge(1-10): ____	Trigger: _____	Coped?:Y/N	Skill used: _____

Highest urge this week: ____ Lowest: ____ Average: ____

Harm-free days this week: ____/7

What helped most this week:

What I'm proud of:

Goal for next week:

MY REASONS TO STAY SAFE

On hard days, come back to this page. These are YOUR reasons.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____
9. _____
10. _____
11. _____
12. _____
13. _____
14. _____
15. _____

You are not your worst moment. You are capable of healing.

COMMUNICATION SCRIPTS

How to Ask for Help

To a friend:

"I'm going through something hard. I don't need you to fix it,
but I need someone to know. Can I talk to you?"

To a parent:

"I need to tell you something. Please listen before reacting.
I've been hurting myself and I want to stop. I need help."

To a therapist:

"I've been self-harming. I want to learn better coping skills.
I'm ready to work on this."

To a teacher:

"I'm struggling with something personal that's affecting me.
I need to talk to the school counselor. Can you help me?"

In crisis:

"I'm not safe right now. I need help immediately.
Please stay with me / Please call 988."

My own words (what feels right for ME to say):

PROFESSIONAL RESOURCES

IMMEDIATE CRISIS:

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: Call or text 988 (24/7)

Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741 (24/7)

Trevor Project (LGBTQ+): 1-866-488-7386

Emergency Services: 911

ONGOING SUPPORT:

To Write Love on Her Arms: twloha.com

Self-Injury Outreach & Support: sioutreach.org

SAMHSA Helpline: 1-800-662-4357

EVIDENCE-BASED TREATMENTS:

- Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT)
- Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)
- Mentalization-Based Therapy (MBT)

MY TREATMENT TEAM:

Therapist: _____ Phone: _____

Doctor: _____ Phone: _____

School Counselor: _____

Support Group: _____

MILESTONES IN MY RECOVERY

☐ 1 day harm-free

Date achieved: _____

How I celebrated: _____

☐ 3 days harm-free

Date achieved: _____

How I celebrated: _____

☐ 1 week harm-free

Date achieved: _____

How I celebrated: _____

☐ 2 weeks harm-free

Date achieved: _____

How I celebrated: _____

☐ 1 month harm-free

Date achieved: _____

How I celebrated: _____

☐ 3 months harm-free

Date achieved: _____

How I celebrated: _____

☐ 6 months harm-free

Date achieved: _____

How I celebrated: _____

☐ 1 year harm-free

Date achieved: _____

How I celebrated: _____

DAILY AFFIRMATIONS FOR RECOVERY

I deserve to be safe.

My pain is valid and temporary.

I am more than my scars.

I am learning healthier ways to cope.

I am worthy of love and support.

One day at a time is enough.

My feelings matter, even the hard ones.

I choose compassion toward myself today.

Recovery is not linear, and that's okay.

I am brave for choosing healing.

SELF-COMPASSION LETTER

Write a letter to yourself as if you were writing to a friend you love:

WHAT I WANT MY FUTURE TO LOOK LIKE

In 1 year, I want:

In 5 years, I want:

People I want in my life:

Things I want to experience:
